

University of Colombo School of Computing

SCS 2312 : Research Methods

D0: Topic Proposal and Research Plan

**“An Investigation into Student Behavior During Free Periods Between  
Scheduled Lectures at UCSC”**

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## Abstract

University students frequently experience unscheduled gaps between their scheduled lectures. These gaps, represent a significant yet largely unexamined portion of a student's daily campus experience. How students choose to occupy this time has implications for academic performance, social interaction, mental well-being, and campus resource utilization.

This proposed study aims to investigate how students at UCSC, utilize their free times during scheduled lectures. The research will focus on five major areas including UCSC Library, Open Area, Dewale, Common room and the UCSC Canteen (Bawana), each affording different types of activity. The study intends to identify common student activities, preferred locations, behavioral patterns, and factors influencing students' choices of these locations and particular activities.

A mixed-method research approach is proposed for the study. Qualitative data collection methods such as observation and short interviews will be combined with quantitative methods including surveys and structured counting. Through these methods, the research expects to develop a broader understanding of student behavior, social interaction, academic engagement, and space utilization within the UCSC environment.

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## List of Acronyms

UCSC – University of Colombo School of Computing

# 1 Introduction

## 1.1 Background

University life consists not only of formal academic activities such as lectures, tutorials, and laboratory sessions, but also of informal periods of time spent between scheduled sessions. These free periods are a routine part of the daily experience of undergraduate students and often influence how students interact with the campus environment, manage their time, and engage socially and academically.

During these unstructured periods, students independently decide how to utilize their time and which campus spaces to occupy. Some students may engage in academic activities such as studying, revising lecture materials, or completing assignments, while others may spend time socializing, relaxing, eating, or engage with their mobile phones until the next lecture starts. The availability, accessibility, and atmosphere of different campus spaces can significantly influence these behavioral choices.

At UCSC, students commonly utilize spaces such as UCSC library, UCSC canteen, common room, dewale and open area during these unstructured periods. Each of these spaces provides different physical and social environments that may influence how students utilize their free time. Understanding these behavioral patterns is important for gaining insight into student well-being, informal learning practices, social interaction, and campus space utilization.

So, our study focuses on investigating how UCSC undergraduate students utilize their free periods between scheduled lectures. The research aims to examine common student activities, preferred campus locations, and the factors influencing behavioral choices during these periods within the university environment.

## 1.2 Problem Statement

Although free periods are a routine aspect of university life, limited attention has been given to understanding how students actually utilize these unstructured periods within campus environments.

At UCSC, students regularly occupy different campus spaces during their free intervals but there is limited evidence regarding how students choose among these locations, what activities they commonly perform, and what factors influence their decisions during free periods. As a result, important aspects of student behavior, informal learning, social interaction, and campus space usage remain insufficiently understood.

Without a clearer understanding of these behavioral patterns, universities may overlook opportunities to improve campus facilities, student support systems, and informal learning environments. Therefore, this study seeks to investigate how UCSC students spend their free periods between scheduled lectures, how campus spaces are utilized during these periods, and what matrices make them choose a particular location, by performing qualitative and quantitative data collection methods.

## 2 Research Topic and its Relevance

### 2.1 Focused Research Topic

#### **“An Investigation into Student Behavior During Free Periods Between Scheduled Lectures at UCSC”**

This research investigates what undergraduate students at the University of Colombo School of Computing actually do during free periods. These gaps are a natural everyday feature of university life even though it's almost entirely unstudied in higher education context.

The study focused specially on 5 physical spaces where student engagement highly happens in UCSC premises. By observing and surveying students across these locations the research aims to build an evidence-based picture of where students go, what they do and why they make those choices during their free time at the university.

Key concepts defined:-

- **Free Period :**

A free period in this context refers to any unscheduled time block during the academic day that falls between two timetabled sessions (lectures, lab sessions, tutorials, exams etc.). It is distinguished from time before the first session of the day or after the final session. These gaps could be in any length based on the timetable for that particular day.

- **Student behavior :**

Behavior refers to observable physical activities that a student engages during a free period. This spread in a vast area from academic activities(studying, reading, revising), social activities(conversations, group discussions) to leisure and personal activities(eating, phone use, playing games, resting). Behavior also encompasses the choice of location where a student goes is itself a behavioral decision.

- **Campus space :**

This study treats 5 selected UCSC locations - library, canteen, common rooms, dewale area and open area. Each space carries different implicit norms and affords different types of activities.

## 2.2 Relevance and justification

- **Unrevealed curriculum of ‘unstructured time’:**

University education does not happen only inside lecture halls. Many studies have shown that what students do outside formal class time is a significant determinant of their overall learning experience and academic outcomes. This is about the informal, unscheduled moments of campus life that shape how students develop intellectually and socially.

Free periods are perhaps the most direct and accessible example of this hidden curriculum. They represent genuine student agency - moments when the student is physically on campus, the institution is not directing them, and they must choose how to invest their time. That choice - to study, socialize, rest, or disengage - has cumulative effects on academic engagement, sense of belonging, and self-regulation skills.

If free periods are being spent entirely on passive leisure (e.g., scrolling phones), this may indicate a mismatch between available campus resources and student needs. If they are being used productively, this is worth reinforcing. Either finding has direct educational implications.

- **Students well being and the quality of the university experience:**

The mental health and well-being of university students has become an increasingly urgent concern in higher education globally. Academic pressure, financial stress, and social isolation are well-documented challenges for undergraduates. How students spend their unstructured time is closely linked to these dimensions of well-being.

Research from multiple contexts has shown that students who feel they have comfortable, welcoming spaces to decompress, socialize, or quietly work during their free time on campus report higher satisfaction with their university experience and lower levels of academic burnout. Conversely, students who feel there is ‘nowhere to go’ between lectures — who drift aimlessly or feel excluded from social spaces — are more likely to disengage from campus life.

- **Institutional Relevance:**

Understanding how students utilize their free periods can provide valuable insights for improving the overall university environment and student experience. Universities invest considerable resources in developing campus facilities such as libraries, common rooms, cafeterias, and open recreational spaces. However, the effectiveness of these spaces depends largely on how students actually use them during daily university life.

By examining student movement, activity patterns, and location preferences during free periods, this study may help identify whether existing campus spaces adequately support students' academic, social, and personal needs. The findings could contribute to discussions related to campus space planning, student support facilities, and informal learning environments within UCSC.

## 3 Preliminary Research Questions

### 3.1 Main Research Question

How do students utilize their free time between scheduled lectures within UCSC premises?

### 3.2 Specific Research Questions

- How much time do students typically spend during free periods between scheduled lectures?
- What types of activities are most commonly performed by students during free periods?
- How do students divide their free time among academic, social, and leisure activities?
- Which campus locations are most frequently occupied during free periods, among the observed ones (Open area, Common Room, UCSC library, UCSC Canteen, Dewale)
- What factors influence students' choice of locations during free periods?
- Do students switch locations during a single free period?
- How many students engage in academic-related activities during free periods?
- Do students spend their free periods alone or in groups?
- Do behavioral patterns differ when students are alone compared to when they are with friends or peers?
- What types of social Activities are common?

## 4 Selected Field Sites

The selected field sites include key student activity areas within the UCSC building, namely the library, common rooms, dewale, canteen, open area, where students typically spend their free time between lectures.

Table 4.1: Selected Field Sites and Expected Student Activities

| Location     | Nature of Space                               | Expected Student Activity                                                                                       |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| UCSC Library | Quiet, academic                               | Academic work including studying, reading, doing assignments, working with laptops                              |
| UCSC Canteen | Social, Informal                              | Eating, casual conversations, group discussions                                                                 |
| Open Area    | Open-air, multi-purpose, relaxing,            | Studying, casual conversations, relaxing, group discussions, informal gatherings, sitting and waiting           |
| Common Room  | Semi-structured, recreational, somewhat quiet | Studying with peers, playing board games, relaxing, practicing for group presentations, small group discussions |
| Dewale       | Informal, multi-purpose, relaxing             | Studying, eating, group discussions, casual conversations                                                       |

## 5 Intended Research Approach

### 5.1 Research Design

The selected research phenomenon contains both qualitative and quantitative dimensions. Quantitative aspects include how many students occupy particular locations during free periods, how frequently different activities occur, and how students distribute their time across campus spaces. Qualitative aspects include why students choose certain locations, how they perceive campus spaces, and what social or personal meanings they attach to their free-period activities. Therefore, a mixed-method approach is considered appropriate for developing a broader understanding of student behavior within the UCSC environment.

The research will be conducted within selected locations of the UCSC premises, including the library, canteen, common rooms, dewale area, and open areas. These locations were selected because they represent commonly used student spaces with different social and academic environments.

The study is intended to be exploratory and descriptive in nature, focusing on observing and understanding naturally occurring student behavior within the campus environment.

### 5.2 Qualitative Data Collection

The qualitative phase of the study will primarily use non-participant observation and short semi-structured interviews to understand student behavior during free periods.

Observation sessions will be conducted at the selected field sites during common free-period hours. Our team will observe how students utilize different campus spaces, the types of activities performed, group interactions, and general behavioral patterns. Observations will focus on visible and naturally occurring behavior without interfering with student activities.

In addition, short informal interviews may be conducted with volunteer students to gain insight into:

- why they choose particular locations,
- how they usually spend free periods,

- what factors influence their behavior,
- and how they perceive the available campus spaces.

These interviews may also include brief follow-up questions based on recurring or observable behavioral patterns identified during the observation phase in order to obtain additional contextual understanding of student activities and space usage during free periods.

Field notes will be maintained during observations and interviews to record behavioral patterns, recurring activities, and emerging themes relevant to the study.

### 5.3 Quantitative Data Collection

The quantitative phase of the study will involve simple measurements, and brief response collection methods in order to identify common behavioral trends among students during free periods.

While qualitative observations and interviews are intended to provide deeper understanding regarding student behavior and activity choices, quantitative data collection will be used to identify measurable patterns related to campus space usage and student movement across different locations and time periods.

A structured questionnaire is expected to be distributed among UCSC students to collect information regarding:

- preferred campus locations
- common free-period activities
- average duration of free periods
- group or individual behavior
- frequency of campus space usage
- and preferred locations during different time periods of the academic day

In addition to surveys, researchers may conduct simple counting-based observations at selected locations. These measurements may include:

- the number of students occupying each space
- the number of students engaged in academic or leisure activities
- group sizes
- and general usage patterns during different time periods.

The collected quantitative data will later be summarized using basic descriptive statistics such as frequencies and percentages.

## 5.4 Feasibility and Ethical Considerations

The proposed study is considered feasible within the available academic timeframe because all selected field sites are accessible within the UCSC premises and the required data collection methods do not require specialized equipment, financial resources, or access to restricted information. The study relies mainly on observation, interviews, surveys, and simple measurements that can be conducted within the normal university environment. This makes the study realistically achievable for a student group within the constraints of an academic semester.

Ethical considerations will also be taken into account during the research process. Participation in interviews and brief follow-up interactions will be voluntary, and no personally identifiable information will be collected from participants. Observations will be conducted only within public campus spaces where student behavior can be naturally observed without direct interference. Any follow-up questions based on observed behavioral patterns will be limited to obtaining general contextual understanding related to student activities and space usage during free periods. The research will be conducted in a manner that respects student privacy, confidentiality, and comfort.

## 6 Conclusion and Future Work

### 6.1 Conclusion

This research proposal focuses on investigating how undergraduate students at the University of Colombo School of Computing utilize their free periods between scheduled lectures within the campus environment. The study aims to explore behavioral patterns, preferred campus spaces, common activities, and factors influencing student choices during unstructured periods of university life.

The proposed research adopts a mixed-method approach by combining qualitative methods such as observation and semi-structured interviews with quantitative methods including structured measurements and brief response collection techniques. This combination is expected to provide both contextual understanding and measurable behavioral trends related to student activities and campus space utilization.

The selected field sites — including the library, canteen, common rooms, dewale area, and open areas — provide diverse academic, social, and recreational environments that are suitable for observing naturally occurring student behavior. The study is considered feasible within the available academic timeframe and is expected to contribute towards a broader understanding of informal student life, campus experience, and space utilization within the UCSC environment.

## 6.2 Future Work

### **D1 – Fieldwork Insights Report**

The next phase of the research will involve direct field engagement through qualitative observation and interaction within the selected UCSC locations. Researchers will conduct structured observations, maintain field notes, and perform short semi-structured interviews with volunteer students in order to identify early behavioral patterns, recurring activities, and preliminary insights related to free-period behavior.

### **D2 – Data Collection Design and Pilot Report**

Based on the findings and observations gathered during the qualitative phase, the research team will design quantitative data collection instruments such as structured response sheets, observation templates, and measurement criteria. A pilot study will then be conducted with a small sample in order to evaluate the clarity, practicality, and effectiveness of the data collection methods before large-scale quantitative data collection begins.

### **D3 – Data Summary and Preliminary Findings**

The quantitative data collected during the study will later be organized, summarized, and analyzed using descriptive statistical methods such as frequencies, percentages, and basic comparisons. Preliminary findings regarding student activity patterns, preferred locations, peak usage periods, and behavioral trends will be identified and compared with the qualitative observations gathered during earlier stages of the research.

### **D4 – Final Research Report**

The final stage of the study will integrate both qualitative and quantitative findings into a comprehensive analysis of student behavior during free periods within the UCSC environment. The final report will critically evaluate behavioral patterns, campus space utilization, informal learning environments, and student experiences while also discussing the strengths, limitations, and possible implications of the research findings for university environments and future studies.